

Bringing them home: On the repatriation of the Piprahwa relics

India must have norms to keep **sacred relics** from being sold

The recent **repatriation** of the Piprahwa relics, which were **excavated** in 1898 from a stupa in Uttar Pradesh, **marked** an important **episode** in India's cultural diplomacy efforts. Considered to be physical **remnants** associated with Lord Buddha's **mortal remains** and his early followers, they were taken away in the **colonial era** and **resurfaced** for **auction** by Sotheby's in Hong Kong in May. At this point, the Indian government **intervened** to **halt** the auction and **repatriate** the relics. These **artifacts** now **reside** in the National Museum, providing people the opportunity to engage directly with an **irreplaceable** piece of India's and Buddhism's **heritage**. **Notably**, India's **coordinated diplomatic effort**, involving multiple ministries and its missions abroad, **could persuade** Sotheby's to postpone and **eventually** cancel the auction. The Godrej Industries Group's **ability** to acquire the relics through a negotiated arrangement with Sotheby's also **reflects** an innovative public-private partnership. Thus, the **collaboration** enabled the repatriation as well as the **setting of a good precedent** for future recoveries, combining private sector resources with state authority. The episode also raised awareness worldwide about India's role as a **steward** of Buddhist heritage.

However, the case has also **revealed** certain structural **deficiencies** in the framework within which India operates to recover and **safeguard** its **cultural assets**. The **relics**, excavated during British **administration**, originally **had** a **fragmented** ownership, **resulting in** a complex legal status that **vexed** repatriation claims a century later. India's reactive **posture** in the episode also **reflected** gaps in the **existing** legal, administrative, and preventive **infrastructure** to manage heritage. **That** the auction was publicly announced and scheduled before India intervened **is revealing**. The case also **exposed** the absence of **robust** international legal frameworks designed to prevent the sale of culturally sensitive objects. While India used existing national laws and international **negotiations** effectively in this instance, it also **banked on** diplomatic pressure, which is not a **scalable** solution. To **address** these gaps, the country needs a centralised, **digitised** registry of cultural assets (domestic and **overseas**) integrated with international customs and auction houses for real-time **monitoring**, **proactive** tracking, and to receive early alerts of **potential** sales. The government could also **spearhead** or actively participate in international efforts to develop binding norms to keep sacred relics from being **commercialised**. **Scaling up** public-private partnerships **is** equally **imperative**, together with encouraging the involvement of **diverse stakeholders**, including **philanthropic** foundations and heritage trusts, to **mobilise** additional resources and **expertise** for recovery and conservation.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Repatriation** (noun) – return, restoration, homecoming, reinstatement, retrieval
वतन वापसी
2. **Sacred** (adjective) – holy, divine, revered, hallowed, sanctified पवित्र
3. **Relics** (noun) – remains, artifacts, remnants, antiquities, vestiges अवशेष
4. **Excavate** (verb) – dig, unearth, uncover, expose, extract खोदना / उत्खनन करना
5. **Mark** (verb) – signify, indicate, denote, symbolize, commemorate चिन्हित करना
6. **Episode** (noun) – incident, event, occurrence, happening, affair घटना
7. **Remnant** (noun) – remainder, residue, leftover, fragment, trace अवशेष
8. **Mortal** (adjective) – human, earthly, perishable, transient, finite नश्वर
9. **Remains** (noun) – leftovers, relics, remnants, ruins, debris अवशेष
10. **Colonial** (adjective) – imperial, overseas, settlement-related, dependent, territorial औपनिवेशिक
11. **Era** (noun) – age, period, epoch, time, generation युग
12. **Resurface** (verb) – reappear, emerge, reemerge, return, materialize पुनः प्रकट होना
13. **Auction** (noun) – sale, public sale, bidding, liquidation, vendue नीलामी
14. **Intervene** (verb) – mediate, intercede, interfere, step in, arbitrate हस्तक्षेप करना
15. **Halt** (verb) – stop, cease, discontinue, pause, terminate रोकना
16. **Repatriate** (verb) – return, restore, send back, remit, reinstate वतन लौटाना
17. **Artifact** (noun) – object, relic, item, antiquity, work of art कलाकृति / पुरावशेष
18. **Reside** (verb) – live, dwell, inhabit, stay, lodge निवास करना
19. **Irreplaceable** (adjective) – unique, invaluable, priceless, unmatched, one-of-a-kind अप्रतिस्थापनीय
20. **Heritage** (noun) – tradition, legacy, inheritance, culture, patrimony विरासत
21. **Notably** (adverb) – especially, particularly, remarkably, significantly, conspicuously विशेष रूप से
22. **Coordinated** (adjective) – organized, systematic, planned, unified, synchronized समन्वित

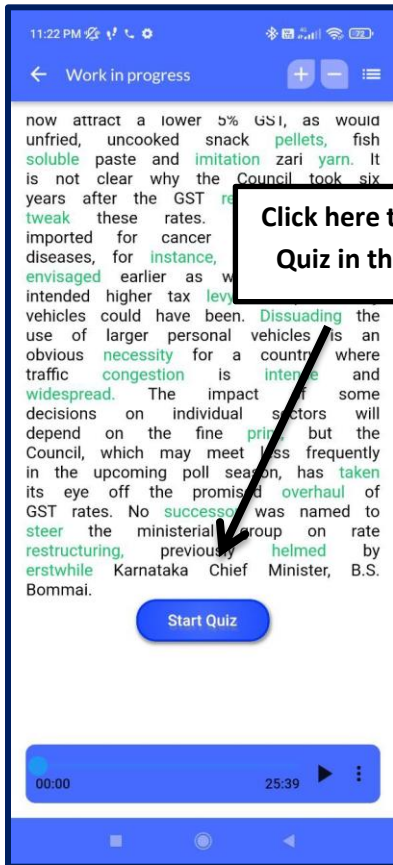
23. **Diplomatic** (adjective) – tactful, political, suave, strategic, conciliatory कूटनीतिक
24. **Persuade** (verb) – convince, influence, sway, coax, induce मनाना
25. **Eventually** (adverb) – finally, ultimately, in the end, at last, conclusively अंततः
26. **Reflect** (verb) – show, indicate, demonstrate, reveal, represent दिखाना
27. **Collaboration** (noun) – partnership, cooperation, alliance, teamwork, association सहयोग
28. **Set the precedent** (phrase) – establish an example, pioneer, initiate, create a standard, blaze a trail नज़ीर स्थापित करना
29. **Steward** (noun) – caretaker, custodian, guardian, manager, overseer संरक्षक
30. **Reveal** (verb) – disclose, expose, uncover, show, manifest प्रकट करना
31. **Deficiency** (noun) – lack, shortage, insufficiency, inadequacy, scarcity कमी
32. **Safeguard** (verb) – protect, defend, shield, preserve, secure सुरक्षित रखना
33. **Cultural asset** (noun) – It refer to the intangible and tangible resources that represent a country's identity, heritage, and values. सांस्कृतिक संपत्ति
34. **Administration** (noun) – management, governance, leadership, supervision, control प्रशासन
35. **Fragmented** (adjective) – broken, divided, splintered, scattered, disjointed टूटा-फूटा / बिखरा हुआ
36. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – cause, bring about, lead to, produce, generate के परिणामस्वरूप होना
37. **Vex** (verb) – annoy, irritate, bother, distress, trouble परेशान करना
38. **Existing** (adjective) – current, present, prevailing, actual, operative वर्तमान
39. **Infrastructure** (noun) – framework, facilities, base, foundation, system बुनियादी ढांचा
40. **Revealing** (adjective) – exposing, disclosing, enlightening, telling, informative खुलासा करने वाला
41. **Expose** (verb) – uncover, reveal, disclose, unmask, lay bare प्रकट करना
42. **Robust** (adjective) – strong, sturdy, resilient, powerful, vigorous मज़बूत
43. **Negotiation** (noun) – discussion, bargaining, talks, mediation, deal बातचीत / वार्ता

44. **Bank** (on) (verb) – rely on, depend on, count on, trust, expect निर्भर करना
45. **Scalable** (adjective) – expandable, adaptable, flexible, extendable, upgradable विस्तार योग्य
46. **Address** (verb) – tackle, deal with, handle, confront, approach हल करना
47. **Digitised** (adjective) – computerized, electronic, virtual, automated, encoded डिजिटाइज्ड / डिजिटल रूपांतरण किया हुआ
48. **Overseas** (adjective) – foreign, abroad, international, external, cross-border विदेशी
49. **Monitoring** (noun) – supervision, observation, tracking, surveillance, oversight निगरानी
50. **Proactive** (adjective) – forward-looking, anticipatory, preemptive, preventive, enterprising सक्रिय / पूर्व-तैयार
51. **Potential** (noun) – possibility, capability, capacity, promise, prospect संभावना
52. **Spearhead** (verb) – lead, initiate, pioneer, champion, front अग्रणी होना
53. **Commercialise** (verb) – market, monetize, merchandise, promote, profit from व्यावसायिक बनाना
54. **Scale up** (phrasal verb) – expand, increase, grow, escalate, enlarge विस्तार करना
55. **Imperative** (adjective) – essential, crucial, vital, urgent, necessary अत्यावश्यक
56. **Diverse** (adjective) – varied, different, assorted, heterogeneous, multiple विविध
57. **Stakeholder** (noun) – participant, investor, contributor, member, shareholder हितधारक
58. **Philanthropic** (adjective) – charitable, humanitarian, benevolent, generous, altruistic परोपकारी
59. **Mobilise** (verb) – organize, rally, deploy, assemble, activate सक्रिय करना / जुटाना
60. **Expertise** (noun) – skill, knowledge, proficiency, competence, mastery विशेषज्ञता

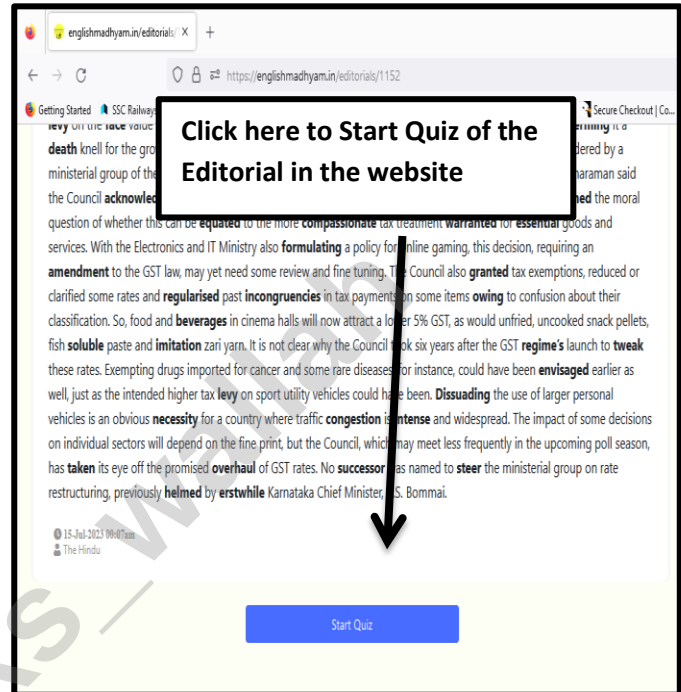
Summary of the Editorial

1. The Piprahwa relics, excavated in 1898 from a stupa in Uttar Pradesh, are linked to Lord Buddha's mortal remains and early followers.
2. They were removed during the colonial era and reappeared in May for auction at Sotheby's in Hong Kong.
3. The Indian government intervened to stop the auction and successfully repatriated the relics.
4. These relics are now housed in the National Museum, offering the public a direct link to India's Buddhist heritage.
5. India's coordinated diplomatic effort, involving multiple ministries and missions abroad, persuaded Sotheby's to cancel the auction.
6. The Godrej Industries Group negotiated with Sotheby's to acquire the relics, demonstrating a successful public-private partnership.
7. This collaboration set a precedent for future recoveries of cultural property.
8. The episode highlighted India's role as a global steward of Buddhist heritage.
9. It also exposed weaknesses in India's legal and administrative framework for protecting cultural assets.
10. Fragmented ownership of the relics, dating back to British rule, complicated legal claims for repatriation.
11. India's reactive approach showed gaps in preventive measures to safeguard heritage.
12. The absence of strong international legal frameworks makes preventing sales of sacred relics difficult.
13. A centralised, digitised registry of cultural assets, linked to global customs and auction houses, is needed for proactive monitoring.
14. India should lead international efforts to create binding norms against the commercialisation of sacred relics.
15. Expanding public-private partnerships and involving philanthropic groups can boost resources and expertise for heritage recovery and conservation.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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